the stock market unless you sell your shares for less than what you paid for them — Walter must have held on and got the benefits of the rebound. His agency ended up being so successful it became one of the 'big three' modelling agencies in the US, notable for its World War II–era pin-up girls. No-one seems to remember that part of Walter's story. (As for why he had been so desperate for cash that he had to sell his car that day, that's been lost to history … )

There were other myths circulating around Black Tuesday, including the harrowing rumours that investors were jumping out of windows after seeing their losses and not wanting to face their families. However, research into suicide rates in the US proved no such thing — in fact, suicide rates were lower during that period. It was purely fearmongering.

One of the biggest things that keeps investors in training from getting started is not their lack of knowledge, but the perpetuation of misinformation. And there sure is some misinformation out there. All it takes is one question about stocks at any family BBQ or work meeting to hear a range of false information about what the stock market is and why you should avoid it.

It seems like every Tom, Dick and Harry has an opinion on what it means to invest, and if you've been brave enough to ask the question, you've probably heard it all:

> *Investing is just gambling.*
>
> *Investing is a con.*
>
> *Only the rich make money, it's rigged.*

Or my favourite,

> *My uncle's friend's son lost all his money in stocks; avoid it at all costs.*

At face value, why would we question these statements? After all, if we don't know much about investing, we might be more likely to trust the opinions of those around us.

Unfortunately, many of these statements, though well meaning, come from the misunderstandings that surround the world of investing. No-one wants to see their family or friend lose money, so if they fear the stock market, of